

ARTS AND CUSTOMS

Cultural life in China blossomed under the Tang and Song dynasties. The empire was usually at peace, and its increasing wealth and prosperity allowed art and culture to flourish. The Tang period is known for its poetry and painting, beautiful porcelain, and glazed earthenware—particularly the ornate clay figures that were placed in graves to accompany the dead.

Under the Song, Chinese painting reached its peak, while porcelain and ceramics were produced to a

very high standard. Poetry flourished, and theater and drama became more complex. The largest theaters in Kaifeng, capital of the Northern Song, could entertain audiences of several thousand. The development of gunpowder enabled the use of fireworks in public festivities, where large displays were often accompanied by dancers moving through clouds of colored smoke.

FACT

The first known written document on tea—*Ch'a Ching* (*The Classic of Tea*) by Chinese writer Lu Yu—was composed during the Tang period.

► HORSES

When the Tang came to power, the government owned only around 5,000 horses, but within 50 years that number had increased to more than 700,000. For the Tang, horses symbolized status and military power. Only the nobility, including women, were permitted to ride. Tomb figures from the period include many horses along with other animals.

EVERYDAY LIFE

During the Tang period, Chinese citizens—especially the upper classes—had a lot of free time to devote to leisure activities. They enjoyed archery, hunting, cuju (a game similar to soccer), tug-of-war, and many more sports. Polo was introduced from Persia in around 700 and became popular among both men and women.



POLO PLAYER

